

Setting up a bridge income. While you search.

Expert networks, fractional work, and consulting engagements that pay during a search — without derailing it or making you look like you've given up on employment.

IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE AWAY

Five things that matter most

- Expert networks (GLG, AlphaSights, Guidepoint) pay \$150-\$500/hour for your existing expertise. Most senior candidates qualify. Takes a week to get started.
- Fractional work is real work. Finance, HR, operations, marketing — companies hire senior fractional leaders for 10-20 hours/week with no long-term commitment.
- Bridge income reduces financial pressure, which produces better decisions in your job search.
- Frame it right: "I'm doing some consulting work while I look for the right full-time role" is completely standard and doesn't raise flags.
- Don't let consulting become a hiding place. Some candidates use it to avoid the harder work of the search. Use it as a bridge, not a detour.

Financial pressure distorts search decisions. The candidate under real financial stress accepts the first offer, negotiates less effectively, and settles for roles that don't fit. Bridge income removes that pressure.

None of these require a long-term commitment. Most can be up and running within two weeks.

EXPERT NETWORKS — FASTEST TO START

Get paid for what you already know

Expert networks connect investment analysts, consultants, and executives at companies with subject matter experts for 30-60 minute phone consultations. If you've worked in an industry for 5+ years, you're likely eligible.

Network	Best for	Typical rate	Time to start
GLG (Gerson Lehrman)	Any industry, very large network	\$150-\$500/hr	3-5 days
AlphaSights	Financial services, consulting, tech	\$200-\$400/hr	3-5 days
Guidepoint	Healthcare, life sciences, industrials	\$150-\$350/hr	5-7 days
Third Bridge	Private equity, strategy consulting	\$200-\$500/hr	5-7 days
Coleman Research	Technology, fintech, consumer	\$150-\$300/hr	5-7 days

How to register

Go to the network's website, submit your LinkedIn or résumé, and describe your areas of expertise. You'll typically hear back within 3-5 business days. The calls are 30-60 minutes. You're paid within 30 days of the call. Register with 2-3 networks simultaneously — the more coverage, the more calls.

Watch for conflicts: Some employment agreements restrict consulting in your industry during a notice period or post-employment. Expert network calls are typically exempt because they're informational — but check your agreement before engaging if the topic area overlaps with your last employer's business.

10-20 hours a week, no long-term commitment

Companies — especially startups and growth-stage businesses — hire fractional executives for finance, HR, marketing, operations, and legal functions when they need senior expertise without a full-time hire.

Platforms and marketplaces

- **Bolster** (bolster.com) — Curated fractional executive marketplace. Finance, HR, marketing, ops. Application required. Strong for Series A-C companies.
- **Toptal** (toptal.com) — Rigorous screening, higher rates, broader functional coverage including tech and finance.
- **Catalant** (gocatalant.com) — Project-based consulting and fractional work. Strong for strategy and operations.
- **Leap** — Fractional CFO, CMO, COO roles specifically. Good for finance and marketing backgrounds.
- **Your own network** — The highest-quality fractional engagements usually come through personal relationships. Tell former colleagues and board members you're available for part-time advisory or fractional work.

What to charge

Fractional rates are typically 1.5-2× what the equivalent full-time hourly rate would be, because you're providing senior expertise without employment benefits or long-term commitment. A VP-level role at \$200K annually = \$100/hr fully loaded hourly equivalent. Fractional rate: \$150-\$200/hr. For C-suite fractional: \$200-\$350/hr is standard.

NEXTCAPTER TOOL

The Fractional & Gig Directory inside NextChapter surfaces the right platforms for your background and helps you build a simple outreach message to former colleagues about fractional availability. Free at launchyournextchapter.com

HOW TO EXPLAIN IT

Framing bridge income in a search

When asked what you've been doing: "I've been doing some consulting work while I look for the right full-time opportunity." This is completely standard for senior professionals and raises no flags when said without apology.

What raises flags: describing consulting in a way that sounds like a full business you're building ("I'm thinking about whether to grow it"), which suggests you're not fully committed to a new role. Say it once, neutrally, and redirect to what you're looking for.

The detour trap: Some candidates use consulting to avoid the harder parts of a job search — namely, asking their network for help. If you find yourself doing more consulting than searching after week six, pause and evaluate. The goal is a bridge, not an exit.